

Guardicore vs. Illumio — Competitive Battlecard

For Axians IT Security AEs — internal use. Respectful, data-based positioning.

Market Context

Both Akamai Guardicore and Illumio are credible, market-leading microsegmentation platforms rated 4.8/5 on Gartner Peer Insights. Illumio is the 'original specialist'; Guardicore was acquired by Akamai in 2021 and benefits from Akamai's security network. For **German manufacturing OT environments**, Guardicore has clear technical superiority.

The Five Key Dimensions

OT / Agentless capability — GUARDICORE WINS

Guardicore NVIDIA BlueField DPU (GA Q2 2026) enables agentless policy enforcement on PLCs, robots, HMIs. No software on OT devices required.	Illumio VEN agents required on each workload. Agentless options exist but are secondary. Acknowledged weakness: 'improve agent performance in OT environments' (PeerSpot).
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Built-in threat detection — GUARDICORE WINS

Guardicore Breach detection, network deception (Akamai Hunt), AI anomaly detection on east-west traffic — all built in.	Illumio Pure segmentation platform. No native threat detection. Customer must integrate separately with SIEM/XDR.
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Network intelligence — GUARDICORE WINS

Guardicore Akamai operates the world's largest commercial network. Trillions of daily observations feed threat intelligence.	Illumio Standalone company. Strong product but no network telemetry advantage.
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Policy granularity — GUARDICORE WINS (complex envs)

Guardicore Flow + process + user-level visibility. AI-assisted policy creation with templates.	Illumio Workload-level L3/L4 policy. Human-readable labels make simple environments easy.
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Commercial / total cost — ILLUMIO ADVANTAGE

Guardicore List price higher than Illumio. Competitive when OT coverage and integrated detection are factored in.	Illumio More cost-effective for simpler, pure-IT, all-agent-capable environments.
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The Three Lines — Use These in Every Competitive Call

1. 'If you have PLCs or industrial robots that cannot run software agents, Guardicore is the only enterprise-grade option — with NVIDIA BlueField now GA.'
2. 'Forrester TEI: Guardicore 152% ROI vs. Illumio 111%. We are both better than doing nothing — Guardicore delivers more for manufacturing environments.'
3. 'Stefan Epp at Victorinox ran both platforms in a real evaluation and chose Guardicore. Happy to arrange a reference call.'